

*A small leather journal. The corners of the cover are worn smooth from years of handling. Inside, entries are numbered by day. Open to the most recent. The handwriting is careful but tired.*

*Day 4,017. Still counting. Still unable to tell them.*

*The mathematics of love and duty: I know the answer, and I cannot say it aloud. The day I found out. That was the day I should have gone to them. I told myself I needed more time. That was 4,017 days ago.*

*What kind of scholar am I?*

*The Aldwyne family wrote again from Solenne. The younger son. He found my address somehow. He wanted to know if I had found what I was "close to understanding." He does not know what he is asking. He does not know that his father and sister are dead because I said I was close.*

*I did not write back.*

*I am still counting.*